

Revised Work Plan

After receiving funding from CIHR's Pandemic Preparedness Priority Fund

2026-09-15

The project failed to obtain funding from the CIHR's main Project Grant program, but received \$100,000 from the Pandemic Preparedness priority stream. This is half the money we applied for, so we must therefore adjust our work plan to fit within this limited budget. This document outlines the reviewers' feedback and a revised work plan that accommodates their concerns and the reduced budget.

The proposal was submitted to the Health Policy and Systems Management (HPM) Research panel (582492; Spring 2026). It was a re-submission of a prior attempt (553620; Fall 2025) directed toward the Knowledge Translation (KT) Research panel.

Reviewer feedback

Our final rating is 3.95/5 (discussed), and was ranked second among the non-funded mainline Project Grant proposals.

- R1: 4.2
- R2: 4.3
- R3: 3.9
- Average: 4.13
- Adjusted: -4.36%

Strengths

- Significance and potential impact are considerable and read as globally relevant, not just Canadian.
- Team is experienced; budget is proportionate.
- Feasibility work already done meaningfully de-risks the project.
- Topic modelling comparison (NMF vs. K-Means, LDA, BERTopic, with coherence scores) is well-detailed.
- Six-phase workflow is clear and generalizable beyond CITF.
- Network analysis is a genuine strength.
- Interview design (recruitment strategy and the three domains) is well-detailed and appropriate.

Weaknesses

Third-party consent in the email corpus. The team has consent and access to the corpus holder's mailbox, but emails involve senders and recipients who didn't individually consent, and it's unclear whether or how their inclusion is covered by ethics approval.

SGBA+/gender treated as an add-on rather than integrated. The feminist framing needs to be operationalized as an analytic thread inside the methods, not confined to a standalone section.

Qualitative/quantitative integration under-specified. How the email analysis and interviews connect needs a stated mechanism, not just a named design.

AI/LLM use for qualitative coding lacks a validation or reflexivity step. Coding assisted by AI needs a formal validation protocol, double-coding a subsample, an inter-rater metric, a reflexivity statement, none of which are present.

Writing quality. Meaningless critique of specific words and phrases that apparently signal use of AI writing tools.

Corpus expansion

The un-funded pilot phase developed the data processing pipeline and also established the feasibility of analysis by subjecting the initial dataset of ~35,000 emails (output: 6,833) to NMF topic modelling, applying the six-phase/five-role coding scheme, and producing the findings at zackbatist.info/CITF-emails/topic-modelling.

The pilot's emails took several months to clean, translate and de-identify — work that Melissa did herself based on Tanya's prior de-duplication effort. The proposal committed to running the same pipeline on additional mailboxes belonging to relevant individuals (e.g. David, Ahmed, Sadun). Expanding the corpus means applying that same protocol to each new mailbox.

Melissa has already established the technique and know-how and is best suited to continue with this work on a part-time basis throughout the Fall 2026 semester, coinciding with her PhD coursework. In accordance with McGill's policies concerning work hours outside PhD activities, her work on the CITF-E-mails data processing will occupy no more than 12 hours per week. In practical terms, Melissa's casual RA contract will be extended beyond August 2026, using funds from the CITF-E-mails grant. At 40\$/hour, 12 hours per week, over 12 weeks (September, October, and November, more or less), the grant will effectively supplement her income by \$5,760.00

The k=14 topics reported in the [preprint](#) and cited in the grant text are specific to the pilot's smaller corpus. All results will need to be updated based on the revised corpus. Both the preprint and grant resubmissions need updated numbers once that's done, and we should consider holding back the preprint before submitting for peer-review.

Questionnaire, replacing interviews

The protocol includes a qualitative component based on interviews with representatives of projects that shared data with the CITF Databank. However, the reduced budget condenses our timeline, and it may be more efficient to pursue a questionnaire-based data collection method instead of interviews. This will reduce overhead of contacting and setting up individual interviews, and provide a more streamlined dataset to work with. We may opt for a two-stage process whereby we contact specific responders to participate in a more open-ended interview. Specific selection criteria will have to be addressed.

The interview guide outlined in the protocol covers three domains that may be translated to the questionnaire: (1) participants' professional backgrounds and experiences, (2) studies' missions, purposes, and motivations, and (3) practices, procedures, and relationships. The questionnaire should be built out of that same structure. The first section may also serve as a mechanism for branching logic, with different kinds of questions for people with different roles.

The emails analysis relates a few primary variables: topics, phases, gender, affiliations, roles. The questionnaire will ask participants' about their gender, affiliation, and role, and questions or blocks of questions will be designed to correspond with topic and phase distinctions ascertained in prior email analysis. There is no need to draw direct relationships between individual email senders and questionnaire respondents; the analysis focuses on aggregate experiences corresponding with roles, genders, and institutional hosts, and parity in our controlled vocabularies for the analysis of emails and questionnaire data allows for comparison of these distinct perspectival and documentary data sources.

It may be helpful to do a brief pilot with 2–3 respondents before full distribution, as a validation and refinement stage.

REB submission

This submission bundles two distinct components with different consent logic. The email corpus (including both pilot and expansion) needs a waiver of consent that's retroactive throughout. The questionnaire needs

standard informed consent, since respondents will be asked directly and nothing has been fielded yet. Zack is currently drafting a REB proposal, which we intend to submit by end of August 2026.

Email corpus: waiver of consent, fully retroactive

The consent gap is specific to third parties, not the mailbox owners. The Operations Manager, Scientific Director and one of two Data Managers have consented to their own mailboxes being used (we have not yet approached the other Data Manager who has left the project, but we anticipate an affirmative response). What's missing is consent from the senders and recipients who corresponded with them. The waiver needs to be scoped and argued as covering that specific population, not framed as if consent is missing across the board.

Submitting now, while the first paper is still an unpublished preprint, also means there's still room to revise if the board asks for changes.

Build the argument around minimal risk. The emails were sent in a professional, institutional capacity, not personal correspondence. De-identification is applied before any analysis or storage of results. Outputs are aggregate and topic-level rather than reproducing individual statements. State plainly that all of the corpus, not just the pilot portion, has been or will be processed under these same safeguards.

One potential concern is use of identifiable information. We do intend to capture people's institutional affiliations, roles and genders. Affiliations will be broad enough to encompass larger institutions that host projects, or kinds of institutions, rather than projects themselves (i.e., University of Montreal rather than [RISC](#); "independent research centre" rather than CanPath). Roles, which characterize a person's responsibilities in relation to a project's collective objectives, will also have to be presented as conceptually distinct from titles, which are identifiable information.

Questionnaire: standard informed consent, fully prospective

Similar concerns as above. We do not collect identifying information; identity is only characterized in terms of relatively abstract categories like roles, institutional affiliations, and gender. Re-state the fact that no direct association is drawn with email records, and that these are parallel tracks.

We will primarily report descriptive or associative statistical findings in aggregate categories large enough to preserve anonymity. However, we will also seek consent to publish specific de-identified passages from questionnaire or interview responses.

Withdrawal needs a stated mechanism, since a respondent could ask to withdraw after their response has already been aggregated. Assign each response a respondent-controlled identifier so a withdrawal request can be matched to their specific response before aggregation, and state a cutoff date after which withdrawal is no longer possible.

Knowledge mobilization

Our knowledge mobilization plan operates on three fronts: partner debrief, publication, and DRAC/GA4GH engagement. While not much needs to change, we should identify specific trigger points to initiate each KM activity.

Fall 2026 / Spring 2027 resubmission

It may be prudent to wait to re-submit for a full Project Grant. We will have greater chance of success once we obtain REB approval, finish expanding the corpus, re-analyzing and submitting the topic modelling paper, and initiating work on the network analysis paper - all of which are feasible prior to March 2027.

We should also consider adding a qualitative methods collaborator.